

BASIC SIGHT-SINGING AND EAR TRAINING FOR CHURCH SINGERS

UNIT 7.1 – FORMS AND STRUCTURES

CATEGORIES OF MELODIES IN ORTHODOX CHANT —

STICHERA



THE FORM AND STRUCTURE OF STICHERA MELODIES

In Unit 3.2 (Slides 13, 14, 15, & 17) we already introduced several of the forms—the **patterns of melodic phrases**—used for **stichera** in the system of “Common” Chant (a.k.a. “Russian Imperial Chapel” Chant).¹⁾ In this unit we present complete examples of stichera melodies in all Eight Tones, in staff notation, using the Stichera Theotokia Dogmatica as examples.

As before, the **macrostructure** of musical phrases is indicated by numbers enclosed in circles. The components of the **microstructure**—“beginning” (intonation), “reciting tone,” and “ending” (cadence)—are indicated by horizontal brackets.

¹⁾Orthodox church singers in 21st-century North America may not be aware of the origins of the 4-part choral arrangements of the Eight Tones sung in many of our churches. First published in 1848, the *Book of Commonly Used Hymns* (Obikhod), prepared under the guidance of Court kapellmeister Alexis Lvov, set down the harmonized versions of the Eight Tones as sung at the Russian Imperial Court Chapel. Revised in 1869 under Nikolai Bakhmetev, this collection has proven remarkably enduring over the past 150 years, adapted into numerous languages, including English.

STUDY NOTES FOR THE SLIDES THAT FOLLOW

For each Tone presented in the following 33 Slides:

1. Read the Analysis and observe and identify the “Things to notice” in each Theotokion Dogmatic Sticheron that follows.
2. In the Form Analysis Exercises 7.1 you will be asked to make **your own** analysis of each sticheron, based on the information presented in this unit.
3. Do the Form Analysis Exercises without looking at the examples in this unit, then use them to check your work.

TONE 1 – STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) – ANALYSIS

The sticheron melody for Tone 1 consists of four melodic phrases (1, 2, 3, 4) sung in rotation and repeated in that order, depending upon the number of phrases in the text. The last phrase of the text, marked “**F**” (for Final) has its own, unique melodic phrase.

Things to notice:

1. The key signature — one flat, which indicates F Major or D Minor.
2. The starting note, G, is RE.
3. The melody “revolves” around the note F (DO), but the most important notes are the G above (RE) and the E below (TI). In singing this Tone, it is important to feel the “attraction” of the TI to DO—to make that interval very small.
4. The Final phrase ends on the note D (LA). In D Minor one would expect to see a C#, and indeed, C# shows up in the Final phrase of the four-part SATB harmonization.

TONE 1 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 1

Theotokion Dogmatikon - Tone 1



Let us praise the Vir-gin **Ma** - ry, the gate of heaven, the



glo - ry of the world, the song of the angels, the beauty of the



faith - ful! She was born of **man**, yet gave **birth** to God.

TONE 1 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 2



She was re-vealed as *the* heav-en, as the temple of the God - head.



She de-stroyed the wall of en-mi - ty. She commenced the peace; she



o - pened the King - dom. Since she is our *foun*-da - tion of

TONE 1 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 3



faith, our defender is the Lord Whom she bore. Cour-age, cour-age, O



pen - ple of God, for Christ will de-~~stroy~~ our en - e - mies, //



since He is all - pow - er - full!

TONE 2 – STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) – ANALYSIS

The sticheron melody for Tone 2 consists of four melodic phrases (1, 2, 3, 4) and a Final Phrase for the last line of text. Phrase 1 is only used for the first line of text, after which Phrases 2, 3, and 4 are sung in rotation and repeated as required by the number of phrases in the text. The formal scheme is 1, 2, 3, 4, 2, 3, 4, 2, 3, 4, etc.... Final.

Things to notice:

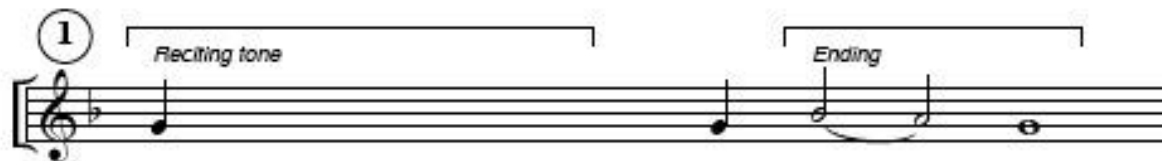
1. The key signature — one flat, suggests F Major or D Minor. However...
2. The starting note, G (RE) is followed, in Phrase 2, by an accidental F# (DI), which is a **leading tone** in the key of G Minor (tonic on G).
3. In Phrase 3, the F# is cancelled by the **natural** sign (♮), which shifts the tonic back to F Major (DO).
4. In Phrase 4, the melody moves up a half step from F-natural to F#, then another half step to G (moving the tonic back to G).

TONE 2 – STICHERON ANALYSIS (CONT'D)

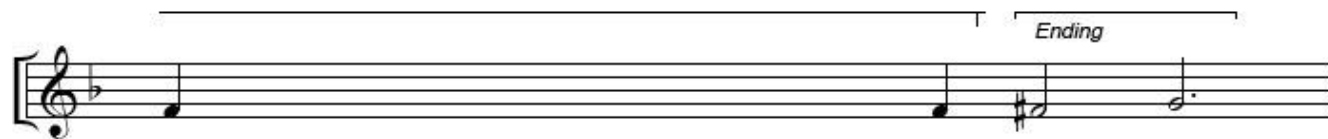
5. The “**dual**” or “**shifting**” **tonic** in of Sticheron Tone 2 is an advanced concept that is somewhat difficult to explain at this point in the course. It is mentioned here for the sake of completeness.
6. Melodic movement by half steps is called **chromaticism**, a phenomenon that is rarely encountered in Eastern Slavic Orthodox chant. Sticheron Tone 2 is one of the rare instances, and makes this Tone challenging to sing in tune, particularly the Alto part, which typically carries the melody.
7. On the positive side, once you have learned to sing consecutive half steps accurately and in tune, you will have learned an important and difficult skill. Practice singing consecutive half steps using SOL-FA syllables:
DO-DI-RE-RI-MI-FA,FI-SOL, etc.
8. The Final Phrase starts on G (RE), similar to Phrase 3, and ends on E (TI), which, again, is not the tonic, but the **leading tone** to the tonic F (DO).

TONE 2 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 1

Theotokion Dogmatikon - Tone 2



TONE 2 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 2



pillar of fire, the Sun of Righteousness has **ris** - en! //



Instead of Moses — Christ, the **Sal - va** - tion of our souls!

TONE 3 – STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) – ANALYSIS

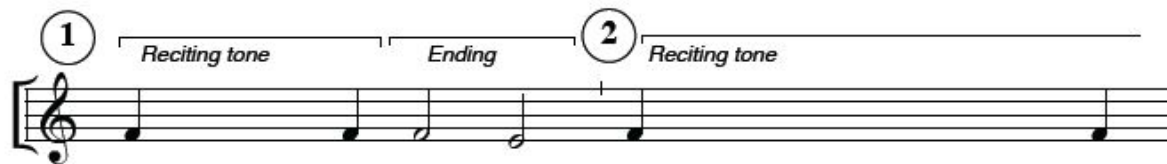
The sticheron melody for Tone 3 consists of two melodic phrases (1 and 2) and a Final Phrase for the last line of text. This is one of the most simple formal structures among the stichera Tones: 1, 2, 1, 2, 1, 2 ... Final.

Things to notice:

1. The key signature — no sharps or flats, suggests C Major or A Minor.
2. The starting note, F (FA) sounds like it might be the tonic, but the second phrase, which ends on C (DO), shows that the tonic is really C.
3. Sometimes one sees Sticheron Tone 3 written with one flat—B-flat, in the key signature, suggesting F Major. But in the harmony of the second phrase, there is a B-natural, which is indicative of C Major. Thus the argument can be made that Sticheron Tone 3, like Tone 2, has a dual or shifting tonic—F and C.
4. Practically speaking, singers must be careful to sing the half step from F to E (FA to MI) very small, and also be careful not to overstep when singing the descending motive of Phrase 2—F-E-D-C (FA-MI-RE-DO).

TONE 3 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 1

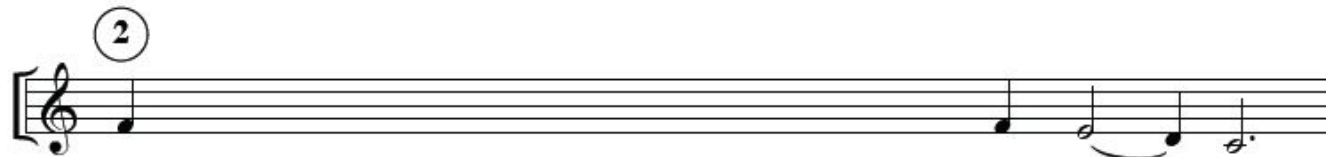
Theotokion Dogmatikon - Tone 3



How can we not **won** - der at Your mystical childbearing,

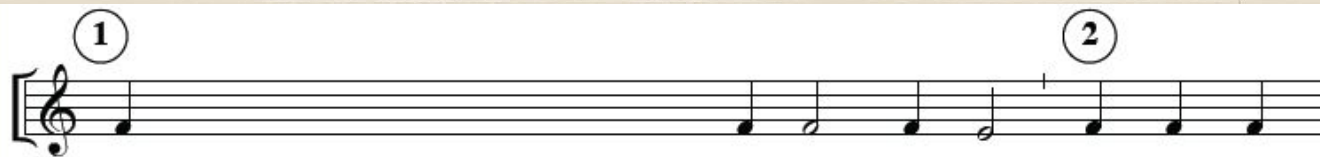


O Exalted **Moth** - er? For, without receiving the **touch** of man,



you gave birth to a Son in the flesh, O Immaculate **Vir** - gin.

TONE 3 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 2



The Son born of the Father before e - ~~ter~~ - ni - ty was born of



you at the fulness of time, O Honored **La** - dy. He underwent no



mingling, no change, no di - **vis** - ion; but preserved the fulness of each

TONE 3 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 3

na - ture. Entreat Him, O Lady and Virgin **Moth** - er,

to save the souls of those who confess you in the Orthodox

F
Reciting tone Ending

man - ner // to **be** the The - o - **to** - kos!

TONE 4 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - ANALYSIS

The sticheron melody for Tone 4 consists of five melodic phrases (1, 2, 3, 4, & 5), with a Final Phrase for the last line of text. After the phrases are sung in order from the beginning, Phrase 3 comes back in a variant, **3a**—with no “beginning” but starting with the “reciting tone” right away, leading some to say that Tone 4 has six melodic phrases. In any case, the order of phrases is 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 3a, 4, 5, 3a, 4, 5, etc.... Final.

Things to notice:

1. The key signature — one flat, suggests F Major or D Minor.
2. The starting note, E (TI), leads to the tonic F (DO).
3. Similar to Tone 1, the melody “revolves” around the note F (DO), but it actually spends more time on the tonic, moving away from it on the phrase endings.
4. The Final phrase ends on the note D (LA). In D Minor one would expect to see a C#, and indeed, C# shows up in the Final phrase of the four-part SATB harmonization.

TONE 4 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 1

Theotokion Dogmatikon - Tone 4

The musical notation is presented on three staves, each with a treble clef and a key signature of one flat (B-flat). The notation uses a combination of quarter, eighth, and half notes, with some notes beamed together. Above the staves, there are numbered circles (1, 2, 3, 4) and brackets indicating specific musical sections: "Reciting tone" and "Ending".

1 Reciting tone Ending 2 Reciting tone

The prophet David was a fa - ther of the Lord through you, O

Ending 3 Beginning Reciting tone Ending

Vir - gin. He fore - told in songs the One who worked won - ders in

4 Reciting tone Ending

you: "At Your right hand stood the Queen, Your Moth - er,"

TONE 4 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 2

5 Reciting tone Ending

the mediatrix of life, since God was freely born of her with-out a

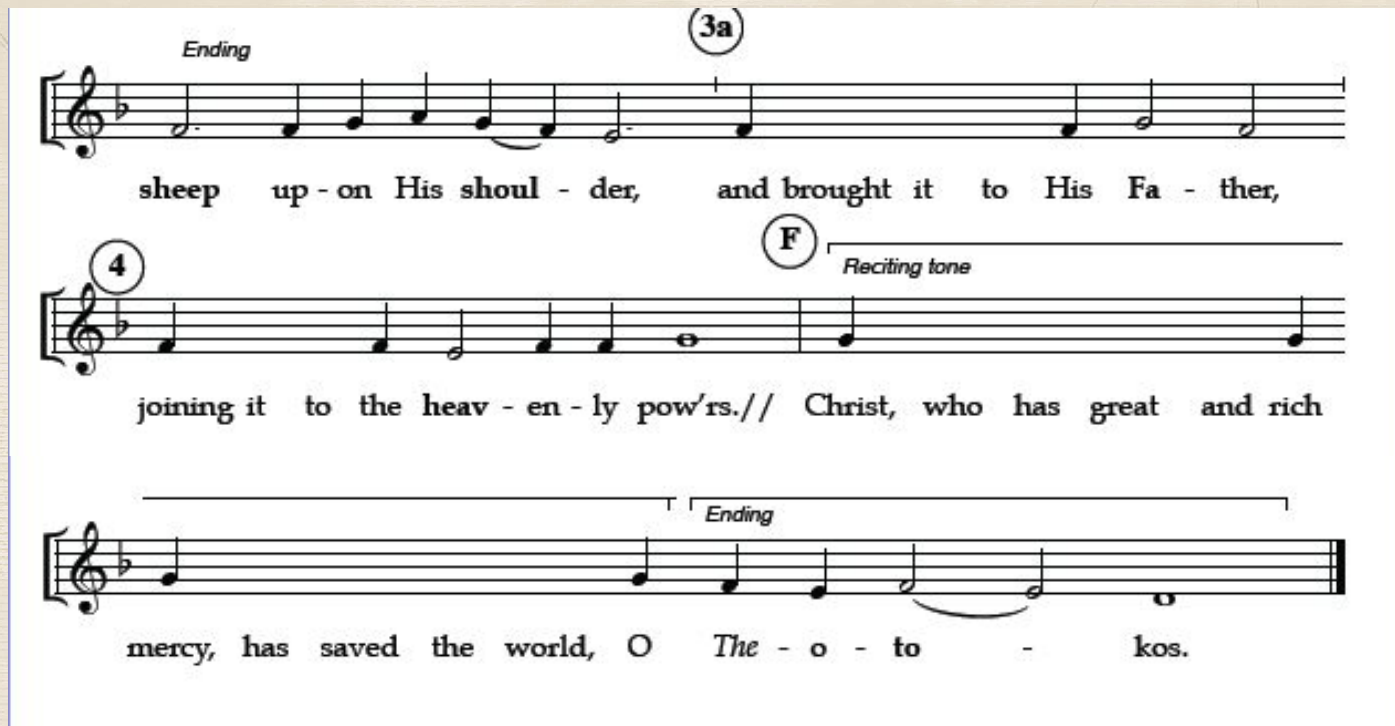
3a Reciting tone Ending

fa - ther. He wanted to renew His fall - en im - age,

4 5

made cor - rupt in pas - sion; so He took the lost

TONE 4 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 3



Ending (3a)

sheep up - on His shoul - der, and brought it to His Fa - ther,

(4) (F) Reciting tone

joining it to the heav - en - ly pow'rs.// Christ, who has great and rich

Ending

mercy, has saved the world, O The - o - to - kos.

TONE 5 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - ANALYSIS

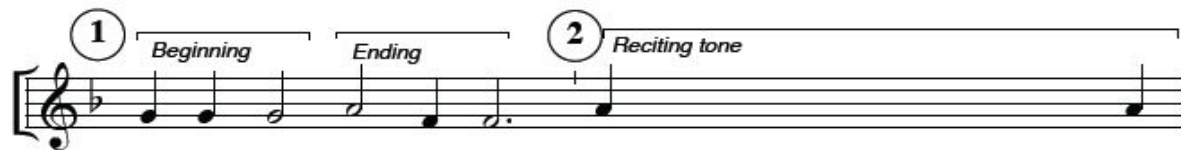
The sticheron melody for Tone 5 consists of three melodic phrases (1, 2, 3), which are sung in rotation as many times as the text requires, plus a Final Phrase for the last line of text. The formal structure is 1, 2, 3, 1, 2, 3, 1, 2, 3, etc.... Final.

Things to notice:

1. The key signature — one flat, suggests F Major or D Minor.
2. The starting note, G (RE), rises to A (MI), before dropping down to F (DO)
3. Phrase 2 begins on A (MI) and drops back to G (RE). Singing the A (MI) consistently high enough is crucial to singing this Tone in tune.
4. Phrase 3 ends on D (LA), again suggesting a feeling of a dual tonic—DO-LA.
5. The Final phrase also ends on the note D (LA). In D Minor one would expect to see a C#, and indeed, C# shows up in the Final phrase of the four-part SATB harmonization.

TONE 5 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 1

Theotokion Dogmatikon - Tone 5



In the **Red Sea** of old, a type of the Virgin Bride was pre-

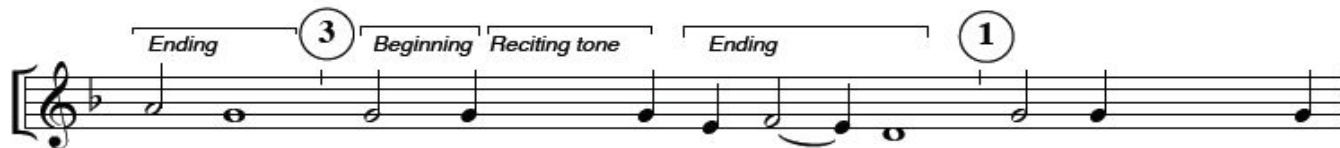
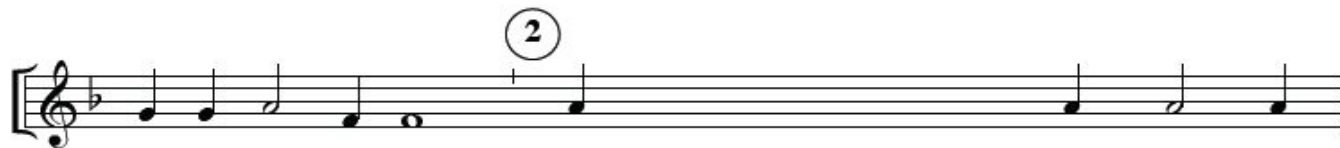


fig-ured. **There** Moses divided the **wa** - ters; **here** Gabriel assisted

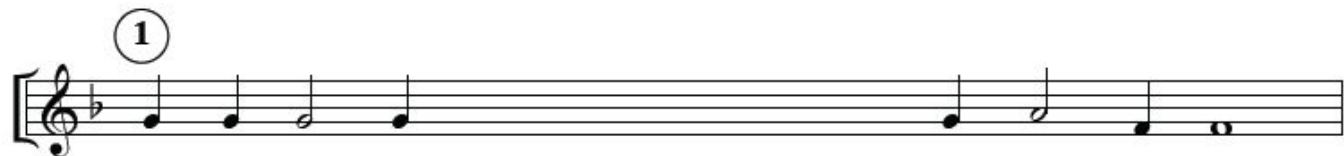


in the **mir** - a - cle. There Israel crossed the sea without **get** - ting

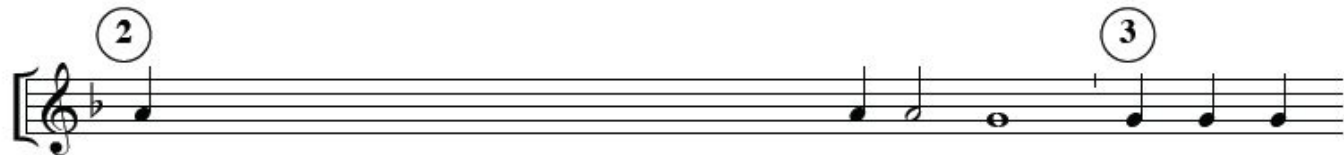
TONE 5 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 2



wet. **here** the Virgin gave birth to **Christ** with - out seed.



Af - ter **Is** - rael's passage, the sea remained im - **pass** - a - ble;



after Emmanuel's birth, the Virgin remained a **Vir** - gin. Ev - er - ex -

TONE 5 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 3



ist - ing God, who ap-**peared** as man, // O **Lord**, have **mer**-cy on us!

TONE 6 – STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) – ANALYSIS

The sticheron melody for Tone 6 consists of three melodic phrases (1, 2, 3), which are sung in rotation as many times as the text requires, plus a Final Phrase for the last line of text. The formal structure is 1, 2, 3, 1, 2, 3, 1, 2, 3, etc.... Final. Phrase 2, when it occurs before the Final phrase, has a variant, **2a**, that descends instead of ascending.

Things to notice:

1. The key signature — one sharp, indicates G Major or E Minor.
2. The starting note, E (LA), drops to an accidental D# (SI), and leads back to E (LA). This would suggest that the starting key is E Minor
3. Phrase 2 moves to F# (TI), which is a leading tone to G (DO), and leads to Phrase 3, which has a major feel, before it drops back to the D#.
4. This repeated melodic movement, SI-LA, TI-DO, DO-TI-LA-SI, again suggests a **shifting** or **dual tonic**, E Minor and its relative major, G Major.

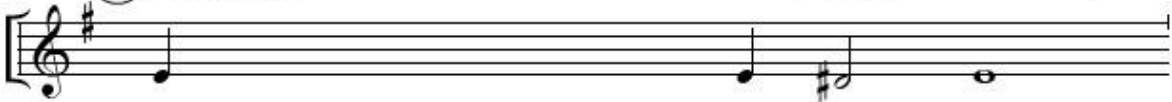
TONE 6 – STICHERON ANALYSIS (CONT'D)

5. The half step movements that are prevalent in Sticheron Tone 6 present challenges when it comes to singing in tune: both half steps—SI-LA and TI-DO, must be sung very small, feeling the gravitational attraction of the respective leading tones to their tonics.
6. Whenever Phrase 2 precedes the Final Phrase, it takes on a different shape: instead of having an upward melodic movement, TI-LA-TI, it descends—TI, LA, SI.
7. Sticheron Tone 6 also has two alternative Final Phrases:
 - a. The simpler of the two is LA-SI-LA, similar to Phrase 1
 - b. The more melodic of the two is LA-TI-DO-TI-LA-SI-LA

TONE 6 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 1

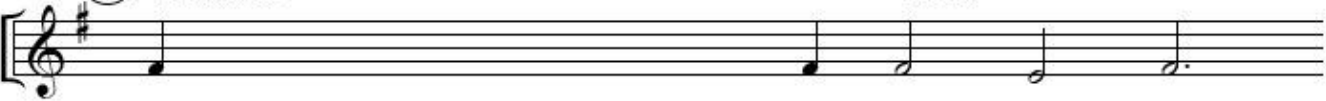
Theotokion Dogmatikon - Tone 6

1 *Reciting tone* *Ending*



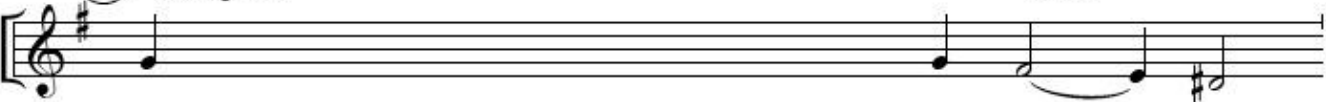
Who will not bless you, most holy **Vir** - gin?

2 *Reciting tone* *Ending*



Who will not sing of your most pure **child** - bear - ing?

3 *Reciting tone* *Ending*



The only-begotten Son shone timelessly from the **Fa** - ther,

TONE 6 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 2

but from you He was ineffably in - **car** - nate! God by nature, yet

man for our sake! Not two persons, but one — known in two

na - tures! Entreat Him, O pure and all - bless - ed

TONE 6 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 3

La - dy, // to have **mer** - cy on our souls!

Alternative final phrase:

to have **mer** - cy on our souls!

TONE 7 – STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) – ANALYSIS

Similar to Tone 3, the sticheron melody for Tone 7 consists of two melodic phrases (1 and 2) and a Final Phrase for the last line of text. The resulting formal structure is: 1, 2, 1, 2, 1, 2 ... Final.

Things to notice:

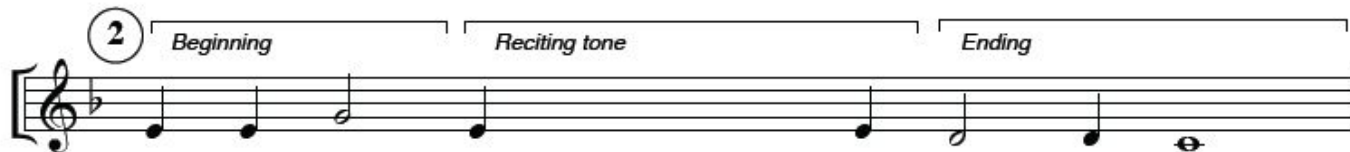
1. The key signature — one flat, suggests F Major or D Minor.
2. As in the case of Tone 1, the melody “revolves” around the presumed tonic note F (DO), but spends most of the time on either the G (RE) or the E (TI).
3. Depending whether the text begins with a stressed syllable or one or more pickup syllables, the melody begins either on TI (stressed) or DO (pickup).
4. As in the case of Sticheron Tone 3, the argument can be made that Sticheron Tone 7 also has a **dual** or **shifting** tonic—F and C, due to the strong melodic movement of Phrase 2 to C.

TONE 7 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 1

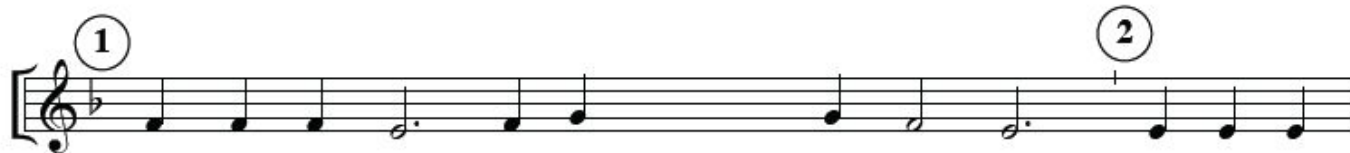
Theotokion Dogmatikon - Tone 7



No tongue can speak of your won - der - ful child - bear - ing



for the or - der of nature was over - ruled by God.



You were re - vealed to be a mother above na - ture, for you re -

TONE 7 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 2

mained a virgin beyond reason and under - stand - ing. Your con -

cep - tion was most glorious, O Theo - to - kos. The man - ner of your

giving birth was ineffable, O Vir - gin. Know - ing you to be the

TONE 7 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 3

2

Moth - er of God, de - vout - ly we pray to you:

F

Reciting tone Ending

"Be - seech Him to save _____ our souls."

TONE 8 – STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) – ANALYSIS

Similar to Tones 5 and 6, the sticheron melody for Tone 8 consists of three melodic phrases (1, 2, 3), which are sung in rotation as many times as the text requires, plus a Final Phrase for the last line of text. After the phrases are sung in order from the beginning, Phrase 1 comes back in a variant, **1a**—with no “beginning” but starting with the “reciting tone” right away. The formal structure is 1, 2, 3, 1a, 2, 3, 1a, 2, 3, etc.... Final.

Things to notice:

1. The key signature — one flat, suggests F Major or D Minor.
2. Depending whether the text begins with a stressed syllable or one or more pickup syllables, the melody begins either on DO (stressed) or TI (pickup); this is opposite from the way texts in Tone 7 begin.
3. The Final phrase also ends on the note D (LA). In D Minor one would expect to see a C#, and indeed, C# shows up in the Final phrase of the four-part SATB harmonization.

TONE 8 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 1

Theotokion Dogmatikon - Tone 8

The musical notation is presented on three staves, each with a treble clef and a key signature of one flat (B-flat). The notation uses quarter notes, half notes, and dotted half notes, with some notes beamed together. Above the staves, circled numbers (1, 2, 3, 1a, 2) indicate different sections of the chant. Brackets and labels above the notes identify these sections as 'Beginning', 'Reciting tone', and 'Ending'. The lyrics are written below the staves, with some words in bold (King, earth, dwelt, Vir) and others in regular font. The text is: 'The King of Heav - en, because of His love___ for man, ap-peared on earth___ and dwelt with men. He took flesh from the pure Vir - gin, and after assuming it, He came'.

1 Beginning "Reciting tone" Ending 2 Reciting tone Ending

The **King** of **Heav** - en, because of His **love**___ for man,

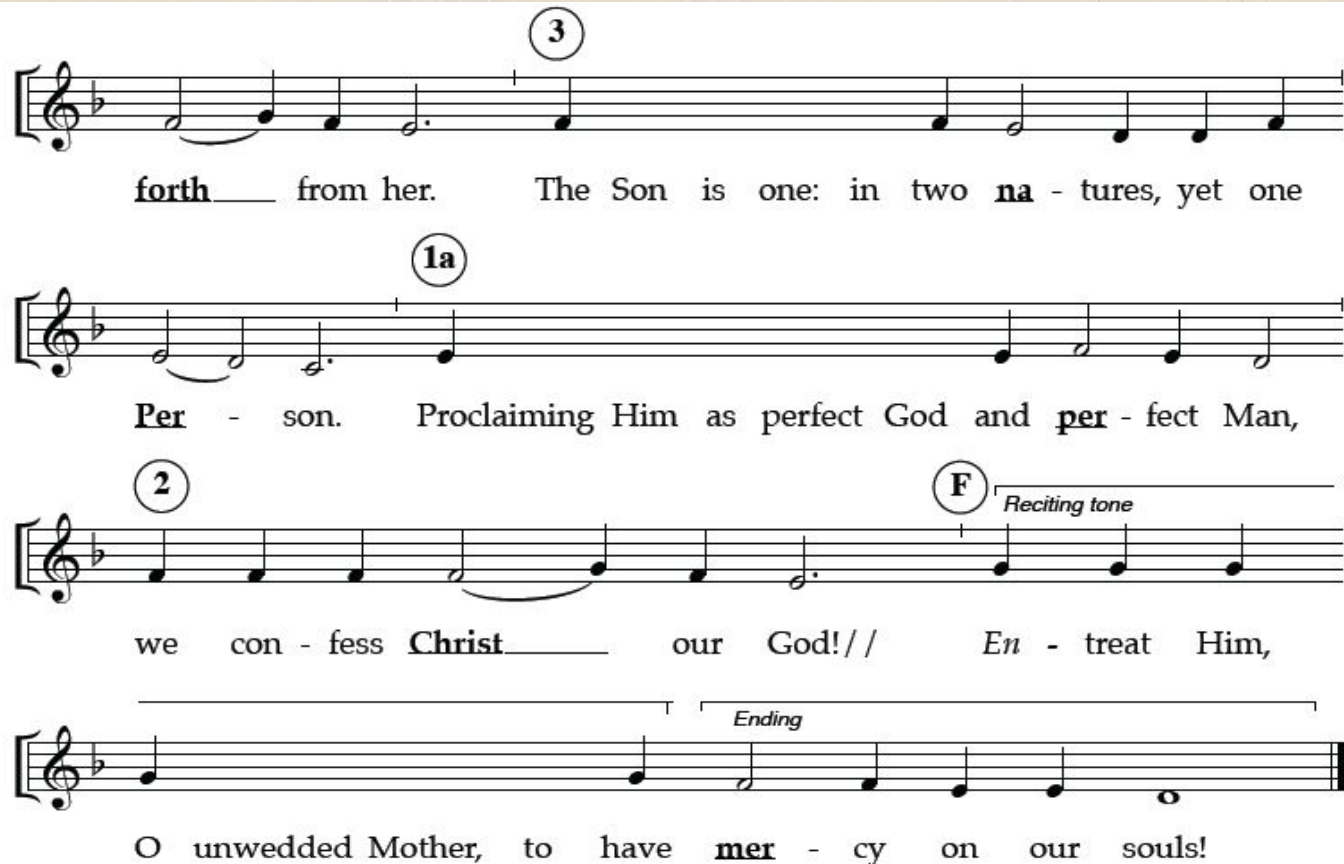
3 Reciting tone Ending 1a Reciting tone

ap-peared on **earth**___ and **dwelt** with men. He took flesh

Ending 2

from the pure **Vir** - gin, and after assuming it, He came

TONE 8 - STICHERON (COMMON CHANT) - 2



③
forth from her. The Son is one: in two **na** - tures, yet one

①a
Per - son. Proclaiming Him as perfect God and **per** - fect Man,

② F Reciting tone
we con - fess **Christ** our God!// En - treat Him,

Ending
O unwedded Mother, to have **mer** - cy on our souls!

Proceed to **FORM ANALYSIS EXERCISES 7.1**

